THE QUESTION OF ZIONISM

Contemporary postcolonial views of history echo Arnold Toynbee's neo-Paulinian view that the Jews were "a fossilized relic" of an extinct civilization, who, because of what he euphemistically calls their economic conflict with Western Gentiles and their incompatibility with a homogenous community, had suffered a tragedy in three acts. Toynbee castigated the sinister and demonic nature of Zionism, that had grown with the rise of Nazism in Germany. It proved his point that "Jewish" characteristics derived not from racial origins but from the peculiar conditions of the Diaspora, which the Israeli Jews were now destroying. Toynbee accused the Israeli "colonizers" of persecuting and dispossessing the Arabs just as the Jews had been dispossessed by the Nazis. They were settling the land in the same spirit as the English Puritans had done in America and the Boers in South Africa, inspired by the biblical books of Exodus and Joshua and smitten by the sin of nationalism.[28] This kind of manipulative reasoning that goes by the name of history in effect makes the equation of the evil of Judaism and Zionism with racism and Nazism. This would become a trademark of Soviet propaganda in the 1960s and 1970s.

The postcolonial understanding of Jews and Israel owes much to the émigré Palestinian Arab critic Edward Said. Said prefaces his classic statement of postcolonial theory, *Orientalism* (1978), with an interesting remark. The history of Orientalism, he writes, in its Islamic branch has mirrored the history of antisemitism—the "secret sharer" of Orientalism. This, he says, is for a Palestinian Arab like himself an irony since he regards Israel as the colonial occupying power, misrepresented in America as democratic in binary opposition to the "evil" Arabs—a prejudice which he constructs as consistent American foreign policy and cultural attitudes. Said presents his study *Orientalism* as an attempt to undo this imagined bigotry which alienates the Palestinian Arab in exile.[29]

Zionism and Orientalism are conflated in *The Question of Palestine* (1979) when Said declares (citing correspondence between Chaim Weizmann and Balfour) that the Zionists cleverly used "Orientalist" rhetoric about the Arabs to trick the British into acquiescence. Said further explains American funding of Israel to be a result of liberal Zionist paternalizing of Palestinian Arabs.[30] Said tried to explain Zionism from the point of view of its "victims" by reiterating that the rhetorical construction of the Balfour Declaration related to real people and a real land, but in doing so he seeks to demolish Zionist claims to the Jewish ancestral homeland as a mere rhetorical device that has no reality. Said essentializes "Zionism" just as much as he accuses "Zionists" of essentializing the Arabs as a colonized people.[31] This Manichean view

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